



The Missouri Breaks

Director: Arthur Penn

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Production Company: Elliott Kastner Corporation

Producers: Elliott Kastner, Robert M. Sherman

Associate Producer: Marion Rosenberg

Production Executive: Jack Grossberg *

Executive Accountant: Stanley Mark

Auditor: Barbara Persons

Unit Production Manager: Malcolm Harding

Location Manager: Les Landau

Location Contact: Earl Rosell

Creative Consultant: Gene Lasko

Production Assistants: Barry Bernardi,

Michael Garrison, Matthew Penn

Secretary to Producers: Toni Howard,

Roberta Lewis, Lori Imbler, Joyce de Vincent

2nd Unit Director: Michael Moore

Assistant Director: Malcolm Harding

2nd Assistant Director: Cheryl Downey

Script Supervisor: John Franco

Screenplay: Thomas McGuane

Director of Photography: Michael Butler

2nd Unit Camera: Rexford Metz

Camera Operators: David Butler, Dick Colean

Assistant Camera: Robert Guthrie,

Michael Nakamura

Key Grip: John Black

Gaffer: Donald Wolak

Stills Photography: Peter Sorel

Special Photographic Effects: Greg Auer *

Special Effects: A.D. Flowers

Editors: Jerry Greenberg,

Stephen A. Rotter, Dede Allen

Assistant Editors: Harvey Rosenstock,

Cynthia Bebout, Angelo Corrao,

Maurice Schell, Rick Shaine

Production Designer: Albert Brenner

Art Director: Stephen Berger

Set Decorator: Marvin March

Property Master: Ray Mercer

Construction Co-ordinator: Hank Wynands

Costume Designer: Patricia Norris

Make-up: Robert Dawn

Hairdresser: Lynn Del Kail

Titles: Wayne Fitzgerald

Music: John Williams

Music Editor: Ken Wannberg

Sound: Jack Solomon, Dennis Maitland

Boom Man: Joe Kenworthy

Cable man: Paul Wolfe

Re-recorders: Dick Vorisek, Trans/Audio

Supervising Sound Editor: Richard Cirincione

Sound Editors: Marc M. Laub, Jack Fitzstephens,

Sanford Rackow, Stanley P. Bochner

Transportation: Joe Sawyers, John Scoggins

Stunt Men: Loren Janes, Walter Scott

Wrangler: Rudy Ugland Jr

Unit Publicist: Jack Casey

Cast:

Marlon Brando (*Robert Lee Clayton*)

Jack Nicholson (*Tom Logan*)

Randy Quaid (*Little Tod*)

Kathleen Lloyd (*Jane Braxton*)

Frederic Forrest (*Cary*)

Harry Dean Stanton (*Calvin*)

John McLiam (*David Braxton*)

John Ryan (*Si*)

Sam Gilman (*Hank Rate*)

Steve Franken (*The Lonesome Kid*)

Richard Bradford (*Pete Marker*)

James Greene (*Hellsgate rancher*)

Luana Anders (*rancher's wife*)

A Road Less Travelled: Harry Dean Stanton

The Missouri Breaks

Described by Philip French as 'a rich, allusive movie, witty, tinged with tragedy, and beautifully lit in the style of paintings by Frederic Remington and Charles Russell,' Arthur Penn's story of cattle rustlers perishing in the face of encroaching capitalism is perhaps best known for its pairing of its two stars. Nicholson impresses as the head of a gang, while Brando is in impish form as a cruel assassin. Stanton proves moving as a man who realises that he is condemned to a grisly fate.

A contemporary review

According to Marlon Brando, he saw his character in *The Missouri Breaks* as an opportunity for 'a serious study of the American Indian.' 'Gee, Marlon, not at these prices,' said Arthur Penn (referring to Brando's \$1.5 million slice of a sizeable budget), so Brando settled for having fun. In the event, the character he plays has become a sort of camp Buffalo Bill with an Irish accent, who makes his entrance playing peekaboo from behind his horse and at one point stalks his outlaw prey in a poke bonnet and dress; and the only reference to Indians in the script comes when rustler Jack Nicholson tells his worried gang about having run across the fabled Pinkerton detective Charlie Siringo while on a jaunt to Wyoming.

Meanwhile, pending the arrival of manhunter Brando from Wyoming, and after an electrifying opening in which the local cattle baron piously hangs a young rustler for the good of his soul – a scene looking and sounding uncannily like a Sunday School picnic – the film itself coasts agreeably along, having fun too. After a fine, freebooting time in the breaks north of the Missouri River in Montana following the Civil War, the frontiers are beginning to close in for the outlaw. The cattle barons are starting to count their losses; the forces of law and order are beginning to organise; and the echoes of *Butch Cassidy* (shorn of the cuteness) are completed by a brilliantly funny railroad robbery in which Jack Nicholson finds himself confronted by a baggage clerk anxious to cooperate in unhitching the mail van but uncertain of his competence.

The change to a tone that grows perceptibly darker comes, paradoxically enough, with the irruption of Brando in a mood of pixillated extravagance as the 'regulator' – in effect a legal hired assassin schooled in long-distance killing for maximum efficiency and self-preservation – summoned by the cattle baron to deal with the rustlers. Perfumed and precious, given to bird-watching while squatting atop his horse with manual in one hand and field-glasses in the other, he yet contrives to evoke a sense of unease by his unpredictable eccentricities. A sense of unease that becomes the chill of fear as his sadism is seen to be allied to a bizarre sexual perversion. (Alone at his campfire, in a scene of lonely despair worthy of Bresson's *Au hasard Balthazar*, he dedicates a love song and a kiss to his horse: 'If the lips were Salome, and the eyes were Cleopatra...')

No less than the flail of God – God being the cattle baron, so referred to twice by other characters as he dons his Sunday black to dispense summary justice – he likes to kill with a harpoon shaped like a crucifix or with his long-range and hideously destructive Creedmore rifle, and even addresses Nicholson as 'angel' in a coy moment when the latter has the drop on him. Though drawn together into a tight knot by the fact that the territory where Brando begins his really murderous operations goes by the name of Hell's Gate, these scattered biblical

Danny Goldman (*baggage clerk*)
Hunter Von Leer (*Sandy*)
Virgil Frye (*Woody*)
R.L. Armstrong (*Bob*)
Dan Ades (*John Quinn*)
Dorothy Neumann (*Madame*)
Charles Wagenheim (*freighter*)
Vern Chandler (*Vern*)
USA 1976©
126 mins
35mm

* Uncredited

A Road Less Travelled: Harry Dean Stanton

Cool Hand Luke

Wed 2 Sep 20:30; Sun 27 Sep 14:45

Escape from New York

Fri 4 Sep 20:55; Tue 29 Sep 18:35

Pat Garrett and Billy the Kid

Sat 5 Sep 20:30; Sun 27 Sep 18:00

The Missouri Breaks

Sun 6 Sep 12:10; Wed 16 Sep 20:30

Wise Blood

Mon 7 Sep 20:55; Sat 19 Sep 18:20

Lucky

Fri 11 Sep 18:15; Thu 24 Sep 21:00;

Thu 1 Oct 20:55

Wild at Heart

Sat 12 Sep 18:10; Fri 25 Sep 20:30; Sat 3 Oct 18:00

Repo Man

Sat 12 Sep 20:50; Fri 18 Sep 18:15

Paris, Texas

Mon 14 Sep 18:00; Sat 26 Sep 20:10;

Sun 4 Oct 18:00

The Straight Story

Mon 21 Sep 18:20; Sat 3 Oct 12:20

Pretty in Pink

Fri 2 Oct 18:10; Mon 5 Oct 20:45

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references are less the central focus of the film than a Manichean comment by Brando: 'I believe life is like a mountain railway... cos' you don't know what sleepy sonofabitch's got his hand on the throttle.'

Although actually set in the 1880s, Thomas McGuane's brilliant script operates on a sort of sliding time scale, reaching back to the early pioneer days or forward to the present to illustrate the implications of this proposition. At the very beginning of the film we are vouchsafed a glimpse of God's country: a vast, empty prairie as the cattle baron and his captive rustler ride endlessly out of the distance to crest the hill like the Mormons gaining their first glimpse of the promised land in Ford's *Wagon Master*. Before proceeding down into the lush little valley for the execution, the condemned man and his judge share a moment of quiet ecstasy as they gaze on this beauty, to preserve which one must kill and the other must die. And in a few lines of dialogue describing how he arrived in a wilderness and now has a vast library of classics back at the ranch, the cattle baron carries us forward a hundred years.

The story of how wealth, culture and influence conspire to create more sleepy sons of bitches reaching for the throttle is taken up by a poor farmer in Hell's Gate who buys some rustled horses and quotes Thomas Jefferson's dictum about how the father clears the ground for the son, before projecting his own aspirations into a playboy vision of society: 'I raise cattle so my son can be a merchant so his son can go to Rhode Island and buy a sailboat and never see these goddam mountains again.' Spelled out like this and divorced from the characterisations that give them body, these historical and theological allusions doubtless sound more schematic than they are, in presenting the thesis that all the sons of bitches who have used violence to keep their hands on the throttle are now seeing the horror boomeranging. But in any case there remains the basic ambivalence. Setting off a petrol bomb to flush out a human torch, Brando's Robert E. Lee Clayton is clearly America in Vietnam; but he also at various times sports an Indian head-band and a coolie hat, and his obscure inner torment suggests that, in these alter egos, the Luciferian revolt may be on another footing entirely.

Along with *Kid Blue*, and of course *Barry Lyndon* in another genre, *The Missouri Breaks* is one of the few recent films to have attempted to render the flavour of period lighting (shadowy golden-browns for the oil-lit interiors, echoing the landscape burning up under the Montana sun), while at the same time avoiding the mistake made by nearly all Westerns under the influence of the dingy, dusty settings favoured by Ince and Griffith (Penn's little farm towns and mining villages are impeccably ramshackle but constructed out of new, rawly cut planks). And in another departure from tradition, Ford especially, the womenfolk are rarely waiting patiently back at the ranch. Although the raunchily innocent heroine (beautifully played by Kathleen Lloyd) is much too open-handed for the film to be accused of misogyny, it undoubtedly takes a bleak view of the matriarchy. Apart from the cattle baron's runaway wife (whose flight from his rectitude has plunged him into puritan mania), the most notable representatives of the gentle sex are two sweet old ladies – one in black with prayer-book in hand, the other in grey with steel-rimmed spectacles pushed up on her brow – who guard the bordello from intrusion by the embarrassed outlaws. Taken together with Brando in his poke bonnet, snuggling down after a day's murderous labour murmuring 'Granny's tired,' they suggest that what the film is really talking about is the rape of God's country by Whistler's mother.

Tom Milne, *Sight and Sound*, Summer 1976